



EVANSTON/SKOKIE
SCHOOL DISTRICT 65

Every Child, Every Day, Whatever it Takes

TO: Evanston/Skokie District 65 School Board

CC: Dr. Angel Turner, Superintendent

**FROM: Melissa Messinger, Executive Chief of Communications;
Dr. Stacy Beardsley, Assistant Superintendent of Accountability**

DATE: August 18, 2025

**RE: SDRP Phase III: Categories and Criteria - Stakeholder
Engagement Summary & Next Steps**

Objective: X Information Discussion Follow-up Decision

Background

The District 65 leadership team is committed to a multi-pronged approach to increase transparency and community voice in the structural deficit reduction planning process and the future of our schools. Each phase of the process has included opportunities to gain stakeholder input.

As part of the third phase, and specifically with the goal of gaining input on the proposed categories/criteria for school closure/consolidation as developed by the Facilities Subcommittee, the District team held a second round of stakeholder engagement.

Stakeholder Engagement

This included two in-person sessions held at Kingsley Elementary (June 24 - 6pm) and Prieto Community Center (June 25 - 9:30am). The District has intentionally rotated sessions across feeder patterns, locations, and times of day to help ensure various opportunities for stakeholders to attend.

Additionally, we have always offered a way to give feedback virtually knowing that there may always be barriers for people to attend in person. The goal is always to collect the same information to develop a more comprehensive analysis.

Our survey was open from June 24-July 7. Despite it being summer and a busy time of year, the District received 865 responses.

Approximately 90 people attended across the two in-person sessions. As with previous engagement sessions, meeting summaries along with independent analysis has been posted to the SDRP Resource Hub on the D65 website and publicly available to the community.

Outreach

At a high level, our outreach efforts included the following:

- Multiple email blasts to all D65 staff, families, and residents who have signed up to receive SDRP related updates
- Multiple text messages to all D65 families with in-person dates and survey links.
- Creation of two 'communications toolkits' for in-person and survey engagement
 - Sent to over 30 community partner organizations, D65 PTA Council, Black Leaders of Evanston, SDRP Steering Committees
- Creation and promotion of "Why Possible School Closures" video
- Posting on D65 website and district event calendar
- Posting in City of Evanston e-newsletter and in various ward newsletters
- Local media outreach and subsequent coverage by the EvanstonRoundtable, Evanston Now, Daily Northwestern, and Evanston Review
- Recurring social media posts and reminders on Facebook and Instagram
- Flyer posting with survey QR codes at JEH Administration Center, distribution at Foster Family Block Party
- Partnership with Evanston Cradle to Career to support flyer distribution and grassroots outreach at in-person community events during survey window

Survey Analysis

Through our NEERA partnership with Northwestern University, District 65 received an independent analysis of the survey and in-person meeting results which has been included in the meeting packet. At a high level, below are the percentages of people who indicated they were 'satisfied' or 'very satisfied' with the proposed criteria by category on the survey. For added context, the percentage of neutral responses are included.

Equity - 58.2%

(neutral - 20.1%)

Geography - 79.8%

(neutral - 10.5%)

Building Functionality - 68.7%

(neutral - 19.1%)

Financial Impact - 57.5%

(neutral - 21.5%)

Overall - 59.7%

(neutral - 25.9%)

Respondents who indicated that they were not satisfied with the criteria had the opportunity to provide open-ended responses as to why they provided the response they did. This additional information was helpful to better understand areas that need to be further considered within the process.

Criteria Finalization

The survey and community engagement feedback along with input provided during the June 23 School Board Meeting were reviewed and summary data was shared with the Facilities Subcommittee. All of the categories received levels of approval over 57% and overall the satisfaction rate was 59.7%.

Category Weighting and Ranking

The Facilities Subcommittee did review questions about category weighting and ranking or values.

Calculations: The subcommittee determined that criteria would be equally weighted in a category and that the data would be normalized to create values between 1 and 5. Below is the process that is being used to generate scores for the scorecard.

Scoring System

- **1** = Least Impactful to Close
- **5** = Most Impactful to Close

Normalization Function

All raw scores are normalized to a 1-5 scale using this mathematical formula:

For Direct Relationships (where higher raw values should get higher scores):

$$\text{Normalized Score} = 1 + 4 \left(\frac{\text{Value} - \text{min}}{\text{Max} - \text{Min}} \right)$$

For Inverse Relationships (where higher raw values should get lower scores):

$$\text{Normalized Score} = 1 + 4 \left(\frac{\text{Max} - \text{Value}}{\text{Max} - \text{Min}} \right)$$

Calculating Impact: Additionally the subcommittee discussed the Equity - Impact Criteria to determine how this particular category will be calculated/assessed to address stakeholder questions. It was determined that this criteria would develop a sum of the number of students that belong to at least one of the marginalized groups named.

A final decision was made to keep the language referring to “Expense for updates”. There was feedback requesting that this language be expanded to bringing buildings up to code which would include items related to sustainability. The team decided to keep the existing language as criteria since this best reflected the contents of the Master Facility Plan and Health Life Safety findings.

Refinement of Equity Criteria

We recognize that transitions can be especially challenging for many. The Committee’s development of this criteria reflects an understanding that major changes, such as school closures, can be particularly disruptive for historically marginalized students and families. These changes may more deeply impact their sense of stability, connection, and progress and be more difficult to overcome.

We also acknowledge the impact of past inequitable practices, which have disproportionately affected students and families of color in this community, and recognize our responsibility to move forward with greater care and accountability.

After careful review of the criteria, feedback from our community, and guidance from our partners, we have growing concerns that explicitly including race and ethnic background could lead to legal challenges. This could slow our progress, add costly expenses, and make it harder for us to focus resources on building a financially sustainable future and ensuring the bright future every student deserves.

The District will continue to use its Equity criteria in building school closure/consolidation scenarios; however, without specific metrics related to race or ethnic background. Equity criteria will still include consideration of socioeconomic status, students receiving special education services, and students receiving English Learner support.

Our District remains committed to fostering equitable learning experiences for all students. As decisions are made, our School Board and Administration will make certain that they do not have an unintended, disparate impact on our communities of color.

Next Steps

Data for each of the categories and criteria have been submitted to our Research, Accountability, Assessment, and Data Department and work is underway on the draft school report cards. The overall scores for individual schools on the scorecards will be used

as an input to select schools for scenario development. Once a scenario is developed, the Facilities Subcommittee will help process the scenario, assess feasibility, and give feedback.

The SDRP Subcommittees (Facilities, Finance, and Student Programming) reconvened as of August 13 and will continue meeting through the fall. There will be several rounds of interaction to arrive at the scenarios to be shared with the School Board and community at the September 29 Regular Meeting. The scenarios most likely will not include just the schools with the lowest scorecard values due to several factors:

- Each scorecard has values that are assessed when a scenario is run.
- Each scenario has an impact on adjacent schools including occupancy rates.
- Schools need to be distributed in each of the District feeder patterns.

Stakeholder engagement sessions and opportunities to share thoughts on the scenarios are being planned for this fall, beginning the week of September 29.